

READING COMPREHENSION — QUESTION PAPER

Performance and Performativity in Anthropology

PASSAGE

Read the following passage carefully and answer the questions that follow.

The concept of "performance" within anthropological studies has undergone a significant metamorphosis over the past few decades. Traditionally, anthropological attention to performance was largely confined to overtly ritualistic, ceremonial, or theatrical contexts – events marked as separate from the mundane fabric of daily life. These were often seen as stylized enactments that reinforced social structures, transmitted cultural knowledge, or mediated relationships with the supernatural. While this focus yielded invaluable insights into the symbolic systems and communal functions of such distinct performative genres, it inadvertently created a dichotomy between "performance" as a special, bounded event and "everyday life" as an unscripted, unreflexive domain.

However, influenced by thinkers like Erving Goffman, who explored the dramaturgical aspects of ordinary social interaction, and Victor Turner, whose later work expanded the notion of "social drama" beyond ritual, contemporary anthropology increasingly recognizes that performance is not merely an adjunct to social life but is constitutive of it. This newer perspective emphasizes "performativity" – the idea that social realities, including identities, roles, and even power relations, are actively and continuously constructed through repeated, stylized bodily acts and utterances. Thus, the seemingly trivial interactions of daily life – a particular way of speaking, gesturing, or dressing – become sites of performance, where individuals negotiate, assert, and sometimes subvert social norms and identities.

This expanded understanding does not negate the importance of studying formal performances; rather, it situates them within a broader continuum of performative practices. It allows anthropologists to ask, for instance, how the codes and conventions of a formal ritual might bleed into or be subtly referenced in everyday comportment, or conversely, how everyday performative styles might be amplified or transformed in a ceremonial setting. Furthermore, this approach highlights the agency of individuals. While social structures and cultural scripts provide a framework, they are not deterministic. Individuals interpret, appropriate, and often creatively manipulate these scripts in their daily performances, leading to both the reproduction and potential transformation of social order.

The methodological challenge for anthropologists, then, is to develop ethnographic sensitivities capable of capturing these more pervasive, often subtle, forms of performativity. It requires moving beyond the observation of demarcated "events" to an attentiveness towards the nuanced ways in which social actors continuously "do" their social worlds into being. This involves a focus on embodiment, discourse, and the contextual interpretation of actions that might otherwise appear insignificant. Ultimately, this shift enriches our understanding of how culture is not just a static set of rules or symbols, but a dynamic, lived process enacted through the myriad performances of its members.

QUESTIONS

Question 1:

The primary purpose of the passage is to:

- A) examine how anthropological thought on performance was reoriented by absorbing key dramaturgical insights from sociology.
- B) trace the evolution in the anthropological understanding of performance, from a focus on discrete events to its recognition as a pervasive aspect of social construction.
- C) argue that recognizing individual agency as a form of performance necessitates a fundamental reorientation of anthropological methodology.
- D) propose that the concept of 'performativity' reveals the study of formal rituals to be a limited, and ultimately secondary, area of anthropological inquiry.

Question 2:

The passage suggests that a key limitation of the 'traditional' anthropological view of performance was its:

- A) creation of an artificial dichotomy between stylized, bounded events and the supposedly unreflexive domain of daily life.
- B) theoretical inability to account for the continuous production and maintenance of social order outside of designated ceremonial contexts.
- C) failure to recognize the role of individual agency and interpretation even within the seemingly rigid structures of formal rituals.
- D) inability to explain how cultural knowledge was transmitted effectively through communal, symbolic enactments.

Question 3:

The concept of "performativity," as distinct from "performance," implies that:

- A) the symbolic codes established in formal, theatrical performances provide the foundational grammar for all everyday performative acts.
- B) the study of everyday interactions offers a more authentic insight into a culture than the study of its stylized, artificial rituals.
- C) social reality is not a pre-existing condition but is continuously brought into being through action.
- D) social identity is primarily an unconscious byproduct of repeated bodily habits rather than a consciously constructed presentation of self.

Question 4:

Which of the following can be inferred as a direct challenge to the methodological shift described in the final paragraph?

- A) The inherent difficulty of verifying an ethnographer's interpretation of an act as 'performative' against the social actor's own understanding of that act.
- B) The practical impossibility of documenting the continuous, pervasive stream of performativity in daily life, as opposed to the discrete, bounded nature of a formal event.
- C) The challenge of synthesizing observations of individual, idiosyncratic performances into a coherent model of a culture's broader social structures.
- D) The difficulty in distinguishing between performative acts and unreflexive, habitual behaviors.

ANSWER KEY & DETAILED ANALYSIS

Question	Correct Answer
Question 1	B
Question 2	B
Question 3	C
Question 4	D

Question 1: The primary purpose of the passage is to:

✓ **Correct Answer: (B)**

- Analyze the Passage Structure:** The passage follows a clear historical and conceptual path. It begins with the "traditional" view (para 1), introduces the "newer perspective" (para 2), and then explores the implications of this "expanded understanding" (paras 3 & 4).
- Evaluate Option B:** This option, "trace the evolution... from a focus on discrete events to its recognition as a pervasive aspect," accurately maps onto this entire structure. It captures the journey from the traditional to the contemporary view, which is the central narrative of the passage.
- Evaluate Other Options:**
 - (A) is a strong distractor. The final paragraph does discuss methodology, but this is a consequence of the evolution, not the primary purpose of the entire passage.
 - (C) misrepresents the author's stance. The passage states the new view "does not negate the importance of studying formal performances," placing them on a "continuum."
 - (D) is a subtle scope error. While influences are mentioned, the focus is firmly on the internal evolution within anthropology.

Question 2: The passage suggests that a key limitation of the 'traditional' anthropological view of performance was its:

✓ **Correct Answer: (B)**

- Identify the Core Task:** The question asks for a "key limitation" of the traditional view, which requires an inference about its fundamental flaw, not just a description.
- Evaluate Option B:** The traditional view saw everyday life as "unscripted." The new view sees performance as "constitutive of" social life, where realities are "continuously constructed." Therefore, the core limitation was its theoretical blind spot regarding the continuous creation of social order in daily life.
- Evaluate Other Options:**
 - (A) is a strong distractor. The "dichotomy" is a result of the limitation, not the limitation itself. The fundamental flaw is the reason for this dichotomy.
 - (C) is an unsupported inference. The passage discusses agency in daily life in the new view but does not state that the traditional view missed agency within rituals.
 - (D) is a direct contradiction. The passage states the traditional view yielded "invaluable insights" into transmitting knowledge.

Question 3: The concept of "performativity," as distinct from "performance," implies that:

✓ **Correct Answer: (C)**

1. **Define "Performativity":** Paragraph 2 defines it as the idea that social realities are "actively and continuously constructed" and that actors "'do' their social worlds into being."
2. **Evaluate Option C:** This perfectly paraphrases the core definition. Reality is not static but is an ongoing process of creation through action.
3. **Evaluate Other Options:**
 - (A) misrepresents the relationship. The passage suggests a two-way influence ("bleed into," "amplified"), not a one-way street where formal performance is the "foundational grammar."
 - (B) is a value judgment the author avoids. It doesn't claim one type of study is more "authentic."
 - (D) is a subtle misreading. The emphasis on "negotiate, assert, and... subvert" implies more than a purely "unconscious byproduct."

Question 4: Which of the following can be inferred as a direct challenge to the methodological shift described in the final paragraph?

✓ **Correct Answer: (D)**

1. **Identify the Methodological Shift:** The final paragraph describes a shift from observing "demarcated 'events'" to capturing "pervasive, often subtle, forms of performativity."
2. **Evaluate Option D:** This gets to the heart of the challenge. If the traditional view saw the everyday as "unreflexive" and the new view sees it as "performative," the primary difficulty for a researcher is telling the two apart. This is a fundamental problem of categorization that precedes interpretation.
3. **Evaluate Other Options:**
 - (A), (B), and (C) are all plausible research challenges, but they are less specific to the core conceptual shift. (A) is about interpretation, (B) is about scale, and (C) is about generalization. (D) is about the fundamental definition of what counts as data under the new paradigm.